

IMAGERY

Descriptive language that appeals to the senses



1 What is it?

Imagery (IM-ij-ree)

Imagery is language that appeals to the **five senses** — sight, sound, smell, taste and touch — to help the reader picture and experience a scene vividly, as if they were really there.

description + a sense (sight/sound/smell/taste/touch)

2 See it in action

Visual imagery

The sky burned orange and violet as the sun dipped below the hills.

Smell imagery

The bakery air was thick with the scent of warm cinnamon.

Touch imagery

The frost bit at her fingers, sharp and stinging in the cold.

Sound imagery

Waves crashed and hissed against the rocky shore.



Keep going!

Ask **which sense** is being triggered — sight, sound, smell, taste or touch — naming it precisely shows strong analysis.

FUN FACT

Studies show descriptive imagery actually activates the same parts of the brain as real sensory experience — reading "the bread smelled delicious" can genuinely make your brain react like you're smelling it.

3 Why writers use it

Imagery helps writers: transport the reader directly into a scene, make writing feel real and immersive rather than just informative, and trigger an emotional response by engaging more than one sense at once.

Imagery is often built using OTHER techniques underneath it — similes, metaphors and onomatopoeia are all common tools used to create strong imagery.

4 Where you'll spot it

Travel writing

Sensory description sells a destination — the smell of street food, the heat on your skin.

Food & recipe writing

Vivid taste and smell imagery is what makes a recipe sound irresistible.



Watch out!

Imagery is a broad "umbrella" term — when you spot it in an exam, always name the specific technique underneath too (e.g. "visual imagery created through a metaphor") for full marks.



Mfalme says...

Look underneath the imagery for the **technique doing the real work** — is it a simile, a metaphor, or onomatopoeia making the image so vivid?

5 Quick recap

Appeals to the 5 senses

Makes scenes feel real

Built using other techniques



Look here!

Try describing your breakfast this morning using all five senses in one paragraph — it's harder (and more fun) than it sounds!